



"When cortisol was first discovered, it was a breakthrough. But we soon realised steroids are a double-edged sword. Have too much and they do the opposite of what's intended"

–DR P.N. RENJEN, *Neurologist, Delhi*

scientific journal *Social Psychological Bulletin*, a research team at the University of Quebec in Montreal, Canada, recommends mindfulness meditation to better handle stressful situations. "Normally, cortisol production is not voluntary," says Dr Hemant Bhargav, who runs the Yoga for Stress Management programme at NIMHANS. "But when one practises mindfulness, there is modulation of the HPA axis." Instead of the sympathetic nervous system that causes your body to respond to stress, mindfulness turns on your parasympathetic nervous system, the doctor adds. The parasympathetic nervous system helps your body relax after periods of stress or danger.

A study published in the *Journal of Ayurveda and Integrative Medicine* in September 2002 found that *pranayama* led to an overall reduction in stress. Doctors say the relaxation could be a result of more oxygen reaching the brain and body through concentrated and mindful breathing. Relaxing your breath—inhaling while counting to 10, for example—also relaxes your body in turn.

However, if the stress is prolonged, then professional help should be sought. "You have to break free of the fear of getting psychiatric help," says Dr Malhotra. "Anti-anxiety medicines, which many people are reluctant to take, are not prescribed as the first line of treatment." Rather, doctors today first look at changing how the patient perceives situations, improving their social relationships and helping them find ways to relax.

Stress is here to stay. If anything, the triggers have only increased—from the pandemic to social media anxiety to increasing job uncertainties to environmental disasters. The ceaseless demands of professional and personal lives too can push people over the edge. The first step towards dealing with stress is to acknowledge that it is a serious health issue. Dismiss it only at your own peril. ■